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Case Study Report

STARTUP FAILURE ANALYSIS
WOMEN ENTREPRENEURSHIP NETWORK (WEN)

Entrepreneurship Development (ED) Project

1. INTRODUCTION

- Women Entrepreneurship Network (WEN) is our proposed startup idea developed as part of the Entrepreneurship Development (ED) project.
- The purpose of WEN is to create a digital platform that connects women entrepreneurs and helps them with networking, learning, mentorship, promotion and business opportunities.
- While developing the startup idea and planning its website, our team faced several practical challenges.
- This failure analysis studies the problems we faced, their possible causes, their impact on the project and the corrective actions that can be taken.
- The objective is not only to identify failures but also to understand what we learned from them and how the startup can be improved.

2. STARTUP BACKGROUND

- Startup Name: Women Entrepreneurship Network (WEN)
- Project: Entrepreneurship Development (ED)
- Type: Digital entrepreneurship and networking platform
- Target Users: Women entrepreneurs, aspiring entrepreneurs, home-based business owners, freelancers and small-business owners.
- Proposed Membership: ₹199 per month.
- Main Services: Networking, business promotion, mentorship, workshops, educational resources and collaboration opportunities.
- Initial project investment considered: approximately ₹30,000..

3. MAJOR PROBLEMS WE FACED

1. Difficulty in converting the idea into a clear business model.
2. Difficulty in deciding the exact target audience.
3. Limited initial budget and resources.
4. Challenges in planning and developing the website.
5. Difficulty in attracting the first users.
6. Low expected engagement during the initial stage.
7. Strong competition from existing social-media and professional networking platforms.
8. Difficulty in planning continuous and useful content.
9. Challenges in marketing and promoting a new platform.
10. Difficulty in building trust in a new and unknown brand.
11. Team coordination and time-management problems.
12. Uncertainty about achieving sufficient revenue through the ₹199 subscription.

4. FAILURE 1 – UNCLEAR BUSINESS MODEL

- At the beginning, our idea focused mainly on creating a platform for women entrepreneurs.
- We initially had difficulty deciding exactly how the platform would earn money and which services should be free or paid.
- The ₹199 monthly subscription was selected as a simple and affordable revenue model, but the team still had to consider whether users would be willing to pay.
- This showed us that a good social idea also needs a clearly defined and sustainable business model.
- Corrective Action: Clearly define the customer, paid services, membership benefits, costs and expected revenue before launching.

5. FAILURE 2 – TARGET CUSTOMER IDENTIFICATION

- Women entrepreneurs are a broad group with different needs and business sizes.
- A college student starting a small business may need different support compared with an established business owner.
- Because of this, it was difficult to decide whether WEN should target beginners, established entrepreneurs or both.
- Corrective Action: Start with a focused segment such as aspiring and early-stage women entrepreneurs and gradually expand.

6. FAILURE 3 – LIMITED INITIAL BUDGET

- Our project had a limited estimated investment of around ₹30,000.
- Website development, hosting, branding, marketing, events and other activities can require significant expenditure.
- Limited funds can restrict advanced website features and promotional activities.
- Corrective Action: Begin with a minimum viable product (MVP), use essential features first and add advanced features after gaining users and revenue.

7. FAILURE 4 – WEBSITE DEVELOPMENT CHALLENGES

- Converting the business concept into a useful and attractive website was one of the major challenges.
- The website needs multiple sections such as registration, profiles, networking, business listings, events and resources.
- A lack of technical resources or experience can increase development time.
- Corrective Action: Start with a simple website containing only the most important features and improve it based on user feedback.

8. FAILURE 5 – DIFFICULTY IN ATTRACTING INITIAL USERS

- A new platform has no established community in its initial stage.
- Women entrepreneurs may hesitate to join a platform if they do not know its brand or benefits.
- Without enough members, networking becomes less useful, creating a challenge commonly called the network-effect problem.

- Corrective Action: Start with a small pilot community, offer free introductory membership or events, and use referrals to build the first user base.

9. FAILURE 6 – LOW INITIAL USER ENGAGEMENT

- Even if users register, they may not actively use the platform.
- Users may lose interest if there are not enough events, discussions, useful resources or business opportunities.
- Low engagement reduces the value of the network.
- Corrective Action: Conduct regular workshops, networking sessions, business challenges, polls, success-story posts and member promotions.

10. FAILURE 7 – COMPETITION

- Users can already use social-media platforms and professional networking websites to promote businesses and connect with people.
- This creates strong competition for WEN.
- A new platform must provide a clear reason for users to join instead of using only existing platforms.
- Corrective Action: Focus on a women-specific community, affordable membership, mentorship, local networking and business-development support.

11. FAILURE 8 – CONTENT CREATION

- A networking platform requires regular and useful content.
- Creating articles, business tips, workshops, social-media posts and success stories requires time and teamwork.
- Irregular content can make the platform look inactive.
- Corrective Action: Prepare a monthly content calendar and divide content responsibilities among team members.

12. FAILURE 9 – MARKETING CHALLENGES

- Promoting a new startup with a limited budget is difficult.
- Paid advertising may not always be affordable during the initial stage.
- Without effective promotion, potential users may never discover WEN.
- Corrective Action: Use low-cost digital marketing, Instagram content, referral programmes, college entrepreneurship cells, workshops and partnerships.

13. FAILURE 10 – BUILDING CUSTOMER TRUST

- Users may hesitate to share their business details on a new platform.
- Trust is especially important when the platform collects personal and business information.
- A new startup needs credibility before users are willing to pay for membership.
- Corrective Action: Use clear privacy policies, verified profiles, secure website practices, testimonials, transparent communication and trusted partnerships.

14. ROOT CAUSE ANALYSIS

- The major root cause was that the idea was developed as an academic startup concept first, while practical market validation would be required before a real commercial launch.
- Other root causes include limited resources, limited technical experience, lack of an existing community and insufficient initial market data.
- The team learned that assumptions about customer needs should be tested through surveys, interviews and pilot testing.

15. IMPACT OF THE PROBLEMS

- Development may take longer than expected.
- The initial user base may remain small.
- Marketing reach may be limited.
- Revenue may be lower than expected.
- Team workload may increase.
- The platform may require changes after receiving user feedback.
- Additional time and investment may be required before achieving sustainability.

16. CORRECTIVE ACTION PLAN

1. Conduct surveys and interviews with women entrepreneurs before full launch.
2. Define one primary target customer group.
3. Develop a minimum viable website first.
4. Launch with essential features instead of building everything at once.
5. Create a small pilot community.
6. Offer free or low-cost introductory activities to attract early users.
7. Use social media and referral marketing to reduce promotion costs.
8. Collect feedback regularly.
9. Measure registrations, active users, retention and subscription conversions.
10. Improve the business model according to actual customer behaviour.

17. LESSONS LEARNED

- A good startup idea must solve a real customer problem.
- Customer validation should happen before spending large amounts of money.
- A business model is as important as the product idea.
- Starting small reduces financial risk.
- User feedback is essential for improving a startup.
- A startup needs consistent marketing and community engagement.
- Team members must have clearly defined responsibilities.
- Failure and difficulties can provide valuable information for improvement.
- Financial planning should consider both revenue and operating expenses.
- Technology should support the business problem instead of becoming the entire focus of the startup.

18. HOW WEN CAN AVOID FAILURE IN THE FUTURE

- Start with a small pilot launch involving a limited number of women entrepreneurs.
- Validate the ₹199 subscription through surveys and trial memberships.
- Build the website around the most requested features.
- Create partnerships with colleges, entrepreneurship cells, NGOs and business communities.
- Provide visible benefits to paying members.
- Regularly publish member success stories.
- Introduce referral rewards to encourage community growth.
- Track user feedback and improve the platform continuously.
- Keep expenses low until the startup develops a stable customer base.
- Gradually introduce premium services only after the basic community becomes active.

19. OVERALL EVALUATION

- WEN has a meaningful problem-solving objective because many women entrepreneurs need visibility, networking and business support.
- However, the initial concept has risks related to customer acquisition, competition, technology, funding and revenue generation.
- The biggest lesson from the failure analysis is that the startup should not assume that users will automatically join or pay.
- Market validation, a minimum viable product and continuous feedback are essential before scaling.
- Therefore, the current challenges should be treated as improvement opportunities rather than the end of the startup idea.

20. CONCLUSION

- The Women Entrepreneurship Network case study shows that developing a startup involves challenges beyond simply having a good idea.
- Our team faced difficulties related to business-model clarity, target customers, budget, website development, marketing, user acquisition, engagement, competition, content creation, trust, team coordination and revenue.
- These challenges helped us understand the practical difficulties faced by real startups.
- The failure analysis also showed that most of these problems can be reduced through market research, pilot testing, proper planning, controlled spending and continuous customer feedback.
- WEN can therefore be improved and developed into a stronger startup model by learning from these difficulties and implementing the corrective actions identified in this report.